Burning Down the House

(Selections From)

By Steve Colman, Roger Bonair-Agard and Alix Olson

INTRODUCTION

In some countries, poets face death; here, in the United States they face apathy. So I welcome the opportunity to be able to share the words of these poets with you. Hopefully they will inspire, inflame, and maybe even provoke you to raise your voice! Through their words, I'm lighting the match . . . starting the fire and . . . Burning Down the House by Steve Colman, Roger Bonair-Agard and Alix Olson.

Wanna Hear a Poem by Steve Colman

I Wanna Hear a Poem
I wanna learn something
I didn't know
I wanna say "YES" at the end,
because I'm sick of saying "so?"

I wanna hear a poem
about who you are
and what you think
Not a poem about my poem - cause I know who I am.

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I wanna hear a
love poem a sad poem an I hate my dad poem
a dream poem an I'm not what I seem poem
an I need poem an I also bleed poem
an I'm alone poem an I can't find my home poem
I just wanna hear a poem!

I wanna hear a poem about revolution
about fists raised high
and hips twisting in a rumble
like a rumba.
I wanna follow
the footsteps of Chè
and hear the truth
about the day
the CIA killed Lumumba.

I wanna hear a poem about struggle
So that
when I open my mouth
I can step outside myself.
I wanna listen to no less
than the sounds of protest
in the factories
where workers sweat
and make Air Jordans

and Pro-Keds.
Because
if you wanna take shots at people
target Phil Knight and Bill Gates
contemplate
how they own the products
and they got the goods
how they act like they care
but they're just Robnin' Hoods.

And because every second matters
I wanna hear long poems
and short poems
about time and its limits
because it took less
than three minutes
to attack Abner Louima
to frame Assata Shakur
and destroy Hiroshima
to kill Eleanor Bumpers
and Anthony Baez
to gun down Malcolm
with bullets
they bought from the Feds.

I wanna hear a poem
where ideas

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kiss similes so deeply
that
metaphors get jealous,
where the subject matters
so much
that adjectives start holding
pro-noun rallies at city hall.
Because I wanna hear a poem
That attacks the status quo
That attracts the claps
Of the cats with the
Phattest flows
That makes the crowd pass
The hat and pack my
Cap with a stack of dough

I wanna guess
your favorite color
then craft rhyme schemes
out of thin air.
I wanna hear a poem
about
why the statute of limitations for rape
is only FIVE F****** YEARS!!!!

I wanna hear a poem
I wanna feel a poem

I wanna taste a poem
I WANNA HEAR A POEM!!!

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier

TRANSITION

You notice that Steve Colman never says . . . I want to READ a poem. That's because in the world poetry today, words are more than letters printed on a page. To TRULY engage in poetry requires both an "author" and an audience. Poems are to be heard, felt, . . even tasted.

Robert Bonair-Agard began learning of the power of words as a child in Trinidad. There, black students learned to read using The Weusi Alfabeti (The Black Alphabet) by Kasisi Yusef Iman, which is illustrated with Pan-African themes. There are drawings and photographs of armed African revolutionaries, pictures of black students, and writings on Malcolm X. That memory inspired this poem: How Do we Spell Freedom? by Roger Bonair-Agard

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How Do We Spell Freedom? - The Weusi Alphabeti Method By Roger Bonair-Agard

I.
In 1970 I learned my alphabet
for the very first time,
- knew it by heart in 1971.
A is for Africa
B is for Black
C is for culture and that's where it's at
my mother taught me that from the Weusi Alphabeti
at a time when A was for apples in a country that grew mangoes
and X was for xylophone when I was learning how to play the steelpan
black wasn't popular
or even accepted then
but I wore dashikis sent to me from Nigeria
super fly suits; sky blue with the elbow patches
sent to me from america
and sandals made by original rastafari before weed & revolution needed fertilizer to grow
my mother rocked bright saffron saris
we were phat 20 years too early and a thousand miles removed
my mother preached hard work

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knowledge and how not to take shit.
D is for Defense
E is for Economics

II.
I wrote my first protest letter at the age of 3
to my grandfather
for calling me in out the front yard
Spelling f*** you with an
    f-o-r-k-U
put it under his pillow in the hope
        it would blow up and burn his ear off at night
  wanted to get started on the revolution thing
F is for Freedom
III.
G is for guns - we gotta get some
        Weusi said

evolved into 1979 and a revolution with a changing face
  **bang bang boogie to the boogie*
  say up jump the boogie - let's rock - yuh don't stop
black folk and brand names became entwined
we re-invented dance and made wheels roll
with a limp
Cuba had just told America he was Africa in Angola
K is for kings
L is for Land - we got to get it back

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        so we lost Jamaica to the IMF
        Grenada to the marines
        and Panama to Nancy Regan
jherri curls became high top fades, became gumbies,
became cesars
as Michael Jackson moonwalked his way into a lighter
shade of pale
        my mother sent me to america - she said
"Go fix that!"

IV.
K is for Kidnap
S is for Slavery - Weusi explained
cool became buttah became phat
  we lost our focus and our way
just at about the time
black folk outside the nation
discovered the dangers of pork
    so fat backs became phat blacks
    pigtails became dreadlocks
    and fades faded to bald
as Michael Jordan discovered the magic of a fadeaway
jumper
    and endorsements

X is for the niggah who's blind deaf and dumb
  X him out – Weusi said

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my mother told me I should re-write that
that X is for the nigga who needs to be re-educated
that a corporate job does not spell freedom
marry white don't mean racist flight
a democratic vote is not a revolutionary act
and as long as there's a sweat shop in Jakarta
there is no difference
between Patrick Ewing and O.J. Simpson

V.
God gave Noah the rainbow sign
- said no more water; the fire next time
J is for James Baldwin – next time is now
H is for Huey
N is for Nat Turner
T is for Tubman
M is for Malcolm, Mandela, Marley & Martin got shot
two weeks after he told black folk to boycott Coca-Cola
Jessie Jackson still scared of niggaz with a purpose.

- and someone must learn to read the signs with me.

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Finalist

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TRANSITION

Audre Lorde once said: There are no new ideas, there are only new ways of making them felt. With all the problems and questions and bewilderments and beautiful troubles of the world, poets have a wealth of ideas. Using words to bring feelings to those ideas is what Alix Olsen has done in "America's on Sale!" She says: "All aspects of our lives have the potential to be politicized: to be articulated, highlighted, crafted in such a way that allows us to see the power relations embedded within whatever it is– and every poem has the power to do that. . . America's on Sale! By Alix Olsen.

America's on Sale! by Alix Olsen

ATTENTION SHOPPERS!!!
attention 9 to 5 folk, cell-phone masses,
the "up and coming" classes,
attention sports-utility,
plastic-surgery suburbanites,
viagra-popping, gucci-shopping urbanites
attention george-clooney loonies,
promise-keeper sheep,
stockbroker sleep-walkers,
big investment talkers,
ricki lake-watchers,
attention walmart congregation,
shop til you drop generation,

ATTENTION NATION!
AMERICA'S ON SALE!

We've unstocked the welfare pantry
to restock the wall street gentry
it's economically elementary,
because values don't pay
yes, american dreams are on permanent layaway,
(there was limited availability anyway)
the statue's of liberty's being dismantled,
$10 a piece to sit on your mantle or hang on your wall
by the small somalian child
you bought from sally struthers
sisters and brothers, it's now or never,
these deals won't last forever-
AMERICA'S ON SALE!
(restrictions may apply if you're black, gay or female).

and shoppers,
global perspective is ninety-ninety percent off
cause most of the world don't count to us
our ethic inventory's low
cause moral business has been slow,
yes, the values-company is moving to mexico--
and ALL ETHICS MUST GO!

it's a remote control america that's on sale
cause standing up for justice can't compare

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to clicking through it from a lazy chair--
Answer: jerry, montel, oprah
Question: folks who really care . . . for $1,000,000,000!

in this new mcveggie burger world order
where national health care is
one-hundred percent off!!
and medicare's in the 50% bin,
so you can buy . . .
half an operation
when AMERICA'S ON SALE!
and there's a close-out bid to determine
which religion will win
all the neon flashing signs of sin
the christian coalition is bidding high
shoppers, you ask WHY!
who needs a higher power when
you've got the purchasing power to corner and market
one human mold.
That's right- Real Family Values are being
UNDERSOLD!!

and it's open hunting season for the NRA!
There's a special oozie discount-- only today!
Gun control?? We say--
black bear, black man, blow em both away!
and Guiliani welfare mamas
are on the auction block again,

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we're closing out this country the way we began.
so step up for our fastest selling commodity
no waiting lines for HIV,
condoms and needle-exchange are a hard to sell thing
(to the right wing)
so if you're a druggie or a fag –
Rent-to-Own your own body bag NOW!
WHILE AMERICA'S ON SALE!

We're selling fast to the AT&T CEO,
he's stealing all utilities,
he doesn't pass go,
and collects $1,000,000 anyway,
he's the monopoly winner
because he bought the whole board
and we bought the whole game
now no price is the same!
cause inflation is up on the CEO ego
and power's deflated as far as you go:

Cause Nike bought the revolution,
and lawschools bought the constitution
tommy hilfiger bought the red, white, and blue,
a flag shirt for fifty dollars,
the one being burned is you!
marlboro bought what it means to be a man,
lexus equals power- so get it while you can.
maybelline bought beauty,

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new york's buying rudy
mastercard gold bought the national soul
Broadway bought talent and called it CATS!
the republicans bought out the democrats
they liquidated all asses in a fat white donkey sale-
now it's buy one shmuck, get one shmuck free
in the capitalist party!
and there's nothing left to get in the way
of a full blue-light blow-out
of the U.S. of A!

there's a no-nothing back guarantee,
a zero-year warranty,
when you buy this land of the free-tos, ruffles, lays..
this home of the braves, the chiefs, the reds, the
slaves!
so call 1-800- i-don't-care-about-shit
or www.F*** ALL OF IT.
to receive your credit for the fate of our nation-
(Call now! Interest is at an all-time low)

BUY IT ALL WHILE YOU CAN!
cause america's being downsized, citizens,
and you're all fired.

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier

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SOURCE INFORMATION FOR ALL POEMS

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AWARD HISTORY FOR THIS SELECTION AS POETRY

2002 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier

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